I really believe that these two levels of personification are not confusing if read in context and in full. The two levels of 'as-if calculation' come to exactly the same conclusion if done correctly: that, indeed, is the criterion for judging their correctness. So, I don't think personification is something I would undo if I were to write the book again today.

Unwriting a book is one thing. Unreading it is something else. What are we to make of the following verdict, from a reader in Australia?

> Fascinating, but at times I wish I could unread it … On one level, I can share in the sense of wonder Dawkins so evidently sees in the workings-out of such complex processes … But at the same time, I largely blame *The Selfish Gene* for a series of bouts of depression I suffered from for more than a decade … Never sure of my spiritual outlook on life, but trying to find something deeper—trying to believe, but not quite being able to—I found that this book just about blew away any vague ideas I had along these lines, and prevented them from coalescing any further. This created quite a strong personal crisis for me some years ago.

I have previously described a pair of similar responses from readers:

> A foreign publisher of my first book confessed that he could not sleep for three nights after reading it, so troubled was he by what he saw as its cold, bleak message. Others have asked me how I can bear to get up in the mornings. A teacher from a distant country wrote to me reproachfully that a pupil had come to him in tears after reading the same book, because it had persuaded her that life was empty and purposeless. He advised her not to show the book to any of her friends, for fear of contaminating them with the same nihilistic pessimism (*Unweaving the Rainbow*).

If something is true, no amount of wishful thinking can undo it. That is the first thing to say, but the second is almost as important. As I went on to write,

> Presumably there is indeed no purpose in the ultimate fate of the cosmos, but do any of us really tie our life's hopes to the ultimate fate of the cosmos anyway? Of course we don't; not if we are sane. Our lives are ruled by all sorts of closer, warmer, human ambitions and perceptions. To accuse science of robbing life of the warmth that makes it worth living is so preposterously mistaken, so diametrically opposite to my own feelings and those of most working scientists, I am almost driven to the despair of which I am wrongly suspected.

A similar tendency to shoot the messenger is displayed by other critics who have objected to what they see as the disagreeable social, political or economic implications of *The Selfish Gene*. Soon after Mrs Thatcher won her first election victory in 1979, my friend Steven Rose wrote the following in *New Scientist*: